

STATEMENT OF DIVERSITY AND INCLUSION

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My journey, shaped by my cultural upbringing, fuels a deep-seated passion for promoting diversity and inclusion within the academic realm. I hail from a middle-income Brahmin family in India, where the foundational principles of *vidya daan*¹ plays a pivotal role, and motivates me to empower others as well to pursue the American Dream.

My family's enduring support has been instrumental, offering me the time and space to pursue academic endeavors without the burden of societal expectations dictating familial priorities. This support, rooted in the principles of understanding and compassion, mirrors my commitment to fostering diversity and inclusion within university settings.

First, in my role as an instructor, I implement pedagogical strategies that promote diversity of thought and ensure that all students feel welcome and valued in the classroom for their unique perspectives and lived experiences. I cultivate an inclusive learning environment that actively encourages diverse perspectives, recognizing that there are no definitive right answers and fostering an atmosphere of open sharing, lively discussion, mutual respect, and intellectual curiosity.

Second, as an academic advisor, my focus is on providing guidance and support to non-traditional students as well. I offer personalized assistance tailored to their specific needs, helping them navigate flexible academic pathways, align their educational pursuits with career goals, and address challenges related to balancing academic requirements with other life commitments. I am dedicated to creating an environment that not only recognizes but also values the diverse experiences and contributions of non-traditional students, ensuring they embark on a positive and successful educational journey.

Moreover, I actively assist and advocate for international students. Recognizing the distinct challenges they encounter, I provide adaptable academic guidance and employment search strategies, all while respecting diverse cultural and religious practices.

Thirdly, as a researcher, my passion extends to collaboration. Actively seeking opportunities to collaborate with diverse teams, I value the richness of varied disciplines, perspectives, and experiences. This collaborative spirit is reflected in both my research pursuits and teaching assignments, contributing to a more comprehensive and representative academic landscape. Importantly, I involve students in my research projects, providing them with valuable hands-on experience, and many have successfully secured employment as a result.

Fourthly, through mentorship, my goal is to empower students to pursue their career goals and become independent individuals. Whether assisting with interview preparation, mentoring for graduate school admissions, or involving students in research projects, I strive to open doors for others, embodying the belief that education can be a force for positive change.

My commitment to "vidya daan" ensures that education becomes a transformative force accessible to every deserving individual, contributing to a more just and equitable society. This commitment aligns seamlessly with the Jesuit values instilled during my predoctoral education (undergraduate and master's). Embracing the Jesuit principles of *cura personalis* (care for the whole person) and *magis* (the pursuit of excellence for the greater good), my vision actively celebrates and amplifies the unique strengths of each individual, going beyond acknowledging diversity to embodying inclusivity in its truest sense.

In conclusion, my education at Jesuit institutions, coupled with the cultural values instilled in me, serves as a complementary foundation to my dedication to diversity and inclusion within the university community. I am enthusiastic about bringing my unique perspective to create an inclusive academic environment that celebrates the strengths of every individual.

¹ Education is a noble and transformative gift that one can offer to others, and providing education is a form of selfless giving and contributes to the betterment of society.